



Nautilus shell cup

△ **Cutaway** of a nautilus shell showing internal chambers

This exquisite object is one of the greatest treasures in the Waddesdon Bequest, a collection of artefacts owned by Baron Ferdinand Rothschild. It consists of a beautiful chambered nautilus shell from Asia, transformed into a goblet in the form of a grotesque sea monster by Western craftsmen. The shell probably came from Guangzhou, China, where its surface had already been decorated with engravings of dragons. In Europe, this type of shell was an exotic novelty only available from the early 16th century, when the Portuguese began trading with Guangzhou. The identity of the Western artist or artists who worked on it is unknown, but experts believe that the work originated in Padua, Italy. The decoration of the cup reflects its nautical origins as well as its cultural influences: in Chinese mythology,

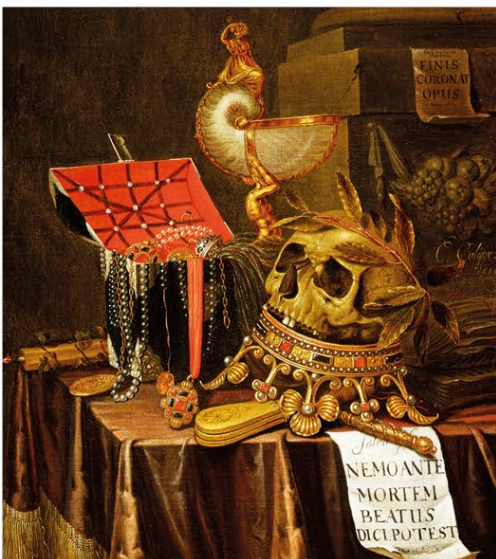


Example of a German nautilus shell cup set in silver gilt, c.1700

dragons lived in undersea caverns and were revered as rain-bringers. The beast is also similar to those portrayed on contemporary European maps, while the boy is Hercules – identifiable by the serpent that he killed in his cot – who later rescued a maiden from a sea monster.

Items of this kind were much sought after by Renaissance connoisseurs, who displayed them in their “Cabinets of Curiosities”. These were

treasure stores of lavish or unusual objects, which were designed to underline the wealth, learning, and worldliness of the collector. The cup's owner, Baron Rothschild, aimed to revive this idea with the New Smoking Room, which he built at his home, Waddesdon Manor. Here, he liked to astound his business associates by showing them his amazing collection of antiques after dinner. Rothschild later donated the contents of the room to the British Museum, on condition that the collection was kept intact.



“Vanitas” still life from 1689 showing a nautilus cup among other luxury possessions. The painting symbolized the transience of wealth

These... are an extraordinary way of mapping the world

Edmund de Vaal

Artist and writer, describing the objects in the Waddesdon Bequest

Key dates

1513–2015

